

Transition Companion — Design Documentation

For Claude Code implementation. This document is the single source of truth for the project.

Project Overview

A web application that helps people navigate gender transition in all its dimensions — legal, medical, social, and personal. Built as a personal tool first, designed from the ground up to become a community resource.

Transition is not a single process with a finish line. It is a collection of parallel, overlapping journeys that happen on different timelines, at different paces, with different levels of safety available to different people. Legal name changes are one small lane. Coming out to a parent, finding an affirming doctor, learning what informed consent means and that you can insist on it — these are the parts people most need guidance on, and the parts least documented anywhere.

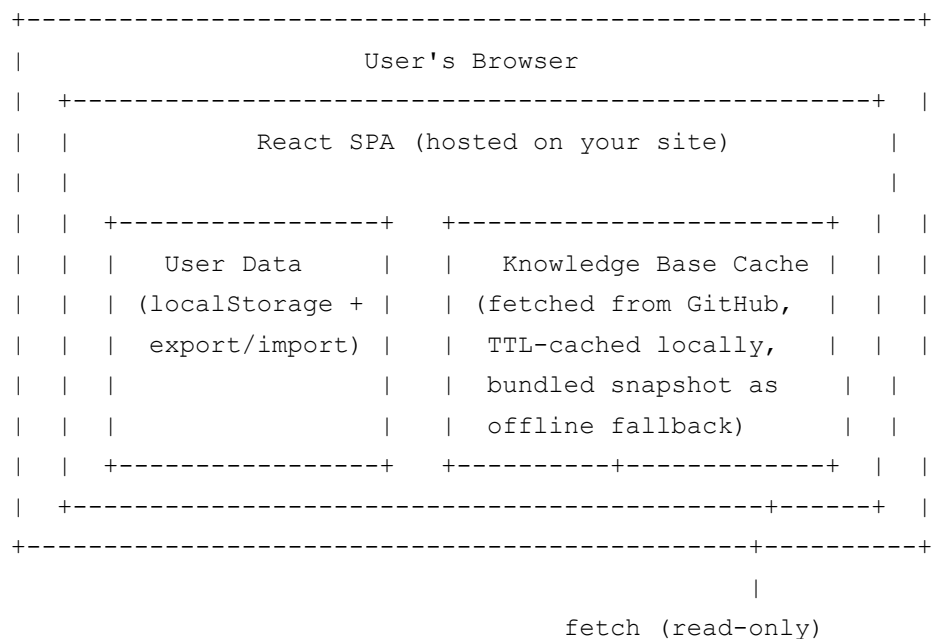
This tool covers all of it. The same architecture — checklist + community knowledge base + safety-aware ordering + personal notes — applies whether the item is “update your SSA record” or “come out to your parents” or “find a gender-affirming therapist.”

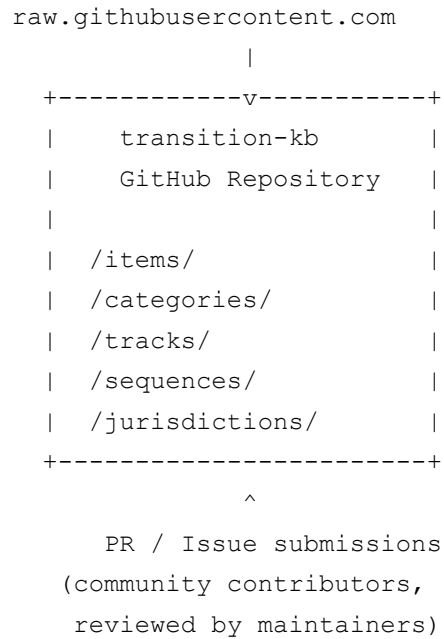
Core philosophy:

- The app is a checklist manager and community knowledge base
- User data stays with the user (local storage and export/import only)
- Community knowledge lives in a GitHub repository — version controlled, contributed by people with lived experience
- No step is too big or too small — from federal documents to a streaming service display name to finding a doctor who treats you like a person
- Useful even with zero KB knowledge for a given jurisdiction, by pointing people in the right direction
- **No judgment, no assumptions** — the app never assumes what someone wants to change, whether they are out, what their name is, or whether they know what they want yet. Every step is optional. Every choice is theirs.

- **Safety is personal and contextual** — what is safe for one person is not safe for another. Someone living with unsupportive family cannot safely update a streaming account without raising questions. Housing status, financial dependence, relationship safety, workplace safety — all of these are real constraints. The app asks about them and respects the answers.
- **Compassion over efficiency** — this tool is used by people who are often emotionally exhausted, navigating hostile systems, doing something deeply personal in a world that is not always supportive. Every word in the UI should reflect that we are on their side.
- **Steps without paperwork are still steps** — the framing is “no documents required” (describing what is not needed), never “easy wins” (which assumes safety and simplicity the app cannot guarantee).
- **Safety-aware** — the political and legal landscape around trans rights changes rapidly and varies dramatically by jurisdiction. The app must clearly flag danger areas, outdated policies, and documented institutional discrimination.
- **This project is itself in transition** — it will never be finished. That is not a bug. The KB is always incomplete. The tool will grow into shapes we have not yet anticipated.
- **Credit:** The “Things Others Need to Update” section was conceived by a spouse/partner of someone going through this process. This tool is for everyone in the orbit of a transition, not just the person transitioning.

Architecture Overview





Why This Architecture

- **Zero hosting cost beyond the existing site** — pure static SPA, no server needed
- **User data never leaves the browser** — no accounts, no data liability, full privacy
- **Knowledge base is a Git repo** — version controlled, community contributed, auditable history
- **GitHub as the backend** — free, reliable, PR workflow handles review
- **Works offline after first load** — KB is cached in localStorage with a 24-hour TTL; app ships with a bundled snapshot as fallback
- **User data and KB cache are stored separately** — bundled KB snapshot is a static import, not in localStorage, to avoid storage quota issues
- **Anonymous contribution** — GitHub issues require no account via the web UI; PRs require an account

Repository Structure

Two separate repositories. Separate is cleaner long-term and allows the KB to be used by other tools.

App Repository (`transition-companion`)

```

transition-companion/
├─ src/
│   ├─ components/
│   │   ├─ onboarding/
│   │   ├─ dashboard/
│   │   ├─ checklist/
│   │   ├─ item-detail/
│   │   └─ contribute/
│   ├─ hooks/
│   ├─ store/                # Zustand state management
│   ├─ utils/
│   │   ├─ storage.js        # localStorage read/write/export/import
│   │   ├─ kb.js             # KB fetching, caching, and fallback logic
│   │   └─ ordering.js       # dependency graph and order-of-operations
│   ├─ i18n/                 # all UI strings externalized here
│   │   └─ en.json           # English strings (default)
│   └─ types/
├─ public/
│   └─ kb-snapshot/          # bundled KB snapshot for offline fallback
└─ package.json

```

Knowledge Base Repository (`transition-kb`)

```

transition-kb/
├─ README.md
├─ CONTRIBUTING.md
├─ schema/
│   ├─ item.schema.json      # JSON schema for all KB items
│   ├─ category.schema.json
│   ├─ track.schema.json
│   ├─ sequence.schema.json
│   └─ jurisdiction.schema.json
├─ tracks/
│   └─ [track-slug].json
├─ categories/
│   └─ [category-slug].json
├─ items/
│   └─ [item-slug].json      # one file per item
├─ sequences/
│   └─ [sequence-slug].json
└─ jurisdictions/
    └─ [country]/
        └─ [region].json

```

Knowledge Base Data Schema

All KB files live in the `transition-kb` repository. The app fetches them from GitHub's raw content CDN: `https://raw.githubusercontent.com/[org]/transition-kb/main/items/[slug].json`

Track

```
{
  "slug": "legal",
  "label": "Legal",
  "description": "Updating name and gender marker with government agencies, finan
  "sort_order": 1
}
```

Category

```
{
  "slug": "government-id",
  "label": "Government ID & Legal Documents",
  "description": "Official documents issued by government entities",
  "track": "legal",
  "icon_key": "id-card",
  "sort_order": 1,
  "tags": ["government", "legal", "identity"]
}
```

Note on `icon_key`: this references a key in the app's chosen icon library (Lucide or Phosphor — Claude Code should pick one and use it exclusively throughout the app). It is not an emoji.

Item (Institution / Step / Resource)

```
{
  "slug": "us-social-security",
  "label": "Social Security Administration",
  "category": "government-id",
  "track": "legal",
  "subcategory": "Federal (USA)",
  "description": "Update your name on your Social Security record",
  "importance": "critical",
  "jurisdiction": {
    "country": "US",
```

```
    "region": null
  },
  "requires": [],
  "required_by": ["us-passport", "us-drivers-license", "most-employers"],
  "immutable": false,
  "immutable_note": null,
  "immutable_compassion_note": null,
  "workarounds": [],
  "process": {
    "summary": "Submit Form SS-5 in person or by mail with original documents",
    "steps": [
      {
        "step": 1,
        "description": "Complete Form SS-5 (Application for a Social Security Card)",
        "modes": ["online", "in_person"],
        "note": "Download or complete online at SSA.gov"
      },
      {
        "step": 2,
        "description": "Gather required documents: court order, current government photo",
        "modes": ["preparation"],
        "note": "You will need originals or certified copies – photocopies not accepted"
      },
      {
        "step": 3,
        "description": "Submit completed form and documents",
        "modes": ["in_person", "mail"],
        "note": "In-person appointment may be required; check ssa.gov for current requirements"
      },
      {
        "step": 4,
        "description": "New card arrives by mail",
        "modes": ["mail"],
        "note": "Typically 2-4 weeks. The card is free."
      }
    ],
    "documents_required": ["court-order", "current-photo-id"],
    "modes_available": ["in_person", "mail"],
    "access_requirements": {
      "internet": "optional",
      "printer": "optional",
      "phone": false,
      "copies": true,
      "notary": false,
      "travel_required": true,
      "travel_note": "Must visit a local SSA office in person"
    }
  },
}
```

```

    "cost": "Free",
    "estimated_time_days": "14-28",
    "url_official": "https://www.ssa.gov/forms/ss-5.pdf",
    "url_info": "https://www.ssa.gov/personal-record/change-your-name.html",
    "notes": "Do NOT send original documents by mail. Send certified copies only.
},
"gender_marker_change": {
  "applies": true,
  "status": "danger",
  "status_note": "As of early 2025, gender marker changes at the federal level
  "status_date": "2025-01-01",
  "markers_historically_available": ["M", "F", "X"],
  "markers_currently_available": [],
  "advocacy_links": [
    {
      "label": "ACLU Trans Rights",
      "url": "https://www.aclu.org/trans-rights"
    },
    {
      "label": "Lambda Legal",
      "url": "https://lambdalegal.org"
    },
    {
      "label": "National Center for Transgender Equality",
      "url": "https://transequality.org"
    }
  ]
},
"discrimination_notes": null,
"presence_level_content": {
  "some_guidance": "The SSA processes name changes separately from gender marke
  "walk_with_me": "Many people find the SSA step feels significant – it is one
},
"last_verified": "2025-01-15",
"verified_by": "community",
"sources": [
  {
    "url": "https://www.ssa.gov/forms/ss-5.pdf",
    "label": "Official SS-5 Form",
    "retrieved": "2025-01-15"
  }
]
}

```

Immutable Item

Some records cannot be changed — not due to discrimination, but because they are historical documents by design.

```
{
  "slug": "us-marriage-certificate",
  "label": "Marriage Certificate",
  "category": "legal-documents",
  "track": "legal",
  "immutable": true,
  "immutable_note": "A marriage certificate is a historical record of an event. I
  \"immutable_compassion_note\": \"This one can be frustrating to discover. Your mar
  \"workarounds\": [
    \"Most institutions that ask for marriage proof will accept the original certi
    \"Your name change court order is legally sufficient for nearly all purposes\"
  ],
  \"process\": null,
  \"jurisdiction\": {
    \"country\": \"US\",
    \"region\": null
  }
}
```

Sequence (Order of Operations)

```
{
  \"slug\": \"us-standard-legal\",
  \"label\": \"Standard US Legal Name Change Sequence\",
  \"description\": \"Recommended order for a US legal name change after receiving a
  \"track\": \"legal\",
  \"jurisdiction\": \"US\",
  \"phases\": [
    {
      \"phase\": 1,
      \"label\": \"Foundation Documents\",
      \"description\": \"These unlock everything else\",
      \"items\": [\"us-social-security\"],
      \"note\": \"SSA must be updated before most government IDs will accept a name
    },
    {
      \"phase\": 2,
      \"label\": \"Government Photo ID\",
      \"items\": [\"us-state-drivers-license\", \"us-passport\"],
      \"note\": \"Updated photo ID is required by most financial institutions\"
    },
    {
```



```

    "phase": 3,
    "label": "Financial Institutions",
    "items": ["banks", "credit-cards", "retirement-accounts"],
    "note": "Most banks require an updated government-issued photo ID"
  },
  {
    "phase": 4,
    "label": "Employment and Benefits",
    "items": ["employer-hr", "us-irs", "health-insurance"]
  },
  {
    "phase": 5,
    "label": "Everything Else",
    "description": "Order does not matter here – work through these at your own
    "items": []
  }
]
}

```

Jurisdiction Override

Allows a region to extend or override the default item data for that jurisdiction.

```

{
  "jurisdiction": { "country": "US", "region": "IL" },
  "label": "Illinois",
  "item_overrides": {
    "us-state-drivers-license": {
      "label": "Illinois Driver's License / State ID",
      "url_official": "https://www.ilsos.gov/",
      "process_override": {
        "summary": "Visit a Secretary of State facility with your documents. Gend
        "gender_marker_change": {
          "status": "current",
          "markers_available": ["M", "F", "X"],
          "process_note": "Self-certification form accepted. No medical documenta
        }
      }
    }
  },
  "region_specific_items": [
    "il-vital-records-birth-certificate"
  ]
}

```

User Data Model (localStorage)

All user data is stored locally in the browser. Nothing is sent to any server.

Two separate localStorage keys:

- `tc_user_data` — the user's profile, checklist, and settings
- `tc_kb_cache` — the fetched KB data with a timestamp for TTL management

The bundled KB snapshot is a static import in the app bundle, not stored in localStorage.

```
{
  "version": "1.0",
  "created_at": "2024-11-15T10:00:00Z",
  "profile": {
    "display_name": "Alex",
    "chosen_name": "Alex",
    "pronouns": "they/them",
    "pronouns_other": null,
    "name_status": "have_new_name",
    "change_types": ["name", "gender_marker"],
    "gender_marker_target": "X",
    "active_tracks": ["legal", "medical", "social"],
    "safety": {
      "housing_status": "independent",
      "housing_note": null,
      "out_to_household": true,
      "household_supportive": true,
      "shared_accounts": false,
      "shared_devices": false,
      "workplace_safety": "out_and_supported",
      "overall_flexibility": "a_lot",
      "safety_note": ""
    },
  },
  "out_contexts": {
    "close_friends": true,
    "partner": true,
    "family": false,
    "work": true,
    "publicly": false
  },
  "jurisdiction": { "country": "US", "region": "IL" },
  "documents_obtained": ["court-order", "updated-ss-card", "updated-drivers-lic"],
  "started_at": "2024-11-15",
  "access": {
    "internet_home": true,
```

```
    "internet_public_only": false,
    "printer_home": false,
    "printer_access": true,
    "printer_access_note": "Library on Main St",
    "copier_access": true,
    "phone_reliable": true,
    "video_call_capable": true,
    "transportation": "public_transit",
    "transportation_note": ""
  },
  "presence": {
    "overall_level": "some_guidance",
    "open_doors": true,
    "per_track": {
      "legal": "just_the_path",
      "medical": "walk_with_me",
      "social": "some_guidance",
      "personal": "walk_with_me"
    }
  },
  "contributor_settings": {
    "privacy_level": "manual",
    "prompting_level": "contextual",
    "involvement_level": "contributor",
    "github_connected": false
  }
},
"checklist": {
  "us-social-security": {
    "status": "complete",
    "completed_at": "2024-11-20",
    "notes": "Sent certified copy of court order by mail. Took 3 weeks.",
    "custom_fields": {}
  },
  "hulu": {
    "status": "complete",
    "completed_at": "2024-11-15",
    "notes": "",
    "custom_fields": {}
  },
  "us-passport": {
    "status": "cant_right_now",
    "blocking_reason": "Need updated driver's license first",
    "notes": "",
    "custom_fields": {}
  }
},
```

```

"custom_items": [
  {
    "id": "custom-001",
    "label": "Change name on gym membership",
    "category": "subscriptions",
    "track": "legal",
    "status": "not_started",
    "notes": ""
  }
]
}

```

Item statuses:

- `not_started` — in the list, not yet begun
- `in_progress` — started, not finished
- `complete` — done, as of the user's knowledge
- `at_risk` — was complete; now under threat due to legal or policy changes outside the user's control
- `revoked` — was complete; has been actively reversed by an external party
- `skipped` — user chose not to do this
- `not_applicable` — does not apply to this user's situation
- `cant_right_now` — user wants to do this but it is currently blocked

`complete` is not a terminal state. External events — policy changes, executive actions, hostile institutions — can move items to `at_risk` or `revoked`. The user's history of completing the item is always preserved. The app never implies the user did anything wrong.

`cant_right_now` is distinct from `skipped`. It means the user wants to do this but something is in the way. The blocker is recorded separately (see Blocker Model below). The app resurfaces `cant_right_now` items when their blockers resolve.

`at_risk` and `revoked` are distinct. `at_risk` means a threat has been identified but the user's status has not yet changed — they should be aware and may want to take action.

`revoked` means the change has already happened to them. Both require the most carefully handled messaging in the app.

Checklist Item Extended Model

```
{
  "us-drivers-license-il": {
    "status": "at_risk",
    "completed_at": "2024-12-01",
    "at_risk_since": "2025-03-15",
    "at_risk_reason": "jurisdiction_policy_change",
    "at_risk_kb_ref": "us-il-gender-marker-2025",
    "revoked_at": null,
    "revoked_reason": null,
    "blockers": [],
    "notes": "Got the X marker with no issues. Staff were great.",
    "custom_fields": {}
  },
  "us-passport": {
    "status": "cant_right_now",
    "completed_at": null,
    "blockers": [
      {
        "id": "blocker-001",
        "type": "document",
        "label": "Need updated driver's license first",
        "kb_dependency": "us-drivers-license-il",
        "user_defined": false,
        "resolvable": true,
        "workaround_available": false
      }
    ],
    "notes": "",
    "custom_fields": {}
  },
  "come-out-to-aunt-margaret": {
    "status": "cant_right_now",
    "completed_at": null,
    "blockers": [
      {
        "id": "blocker-002",
        "type": "relationship",
        "label": "Not sure she is safe",
        "person_ref": "person-aunt-margaret",
        "user_defined": true,
        "resolvable": "maybe",
        "workaround_available": true,
        "workaround_note": "Some things do not require her to know. Passport, for
      }
    ]
  }
}
```

```

    ],
    "notes": "",
    "custom_fields": {}
  }
}

```

People Map

The user can build a personal map of the people in their life and their relationship to the user's transition. This feeds directly into blocker logic and the social track.

No one is required to be added. The map is entirely optional and private.

```

{
  "people": {
    "person-aunt-margaret": {
      "id": "person-aunt-margaret",
      "label": "Aunt Margaret",
      "relationship": "extended_family",
      "out_to": false,
      "out_status": "not_out",
      "safety_level": "unsure",
      "safety_note": "Never talks politics. Hard to read. Probably fine but not s
      "support_level": null,
      "support_note": null,
      "contact_frequency": "holidays_only",
      "items_they_need_to_update": [],
      "user_notes": "She gave me a sweater last Christmas that was actually prett
    },
    "person-dad": {
      "id": "person-dad",
      "label": "Dad",
      "relationship": "parent",
      "out_to": true,
      "out_status": "out",
      "safety_level": "safe",
      "support_level": "words_not_actions",
      "support_note": "Says he supports me but still uses old name sometimes. Not
      "contact_frequency": "weekly",
      "items_they_need_to_update": ["emergency-contact", "will-beneficiary"],
      "user_notes": ""
    },
    "person-wife": {
      "id": "person-wife",
      "label": "Wife",

```

```

    "relationship": "partner",
    "out_to": true,
    "out_status": "out",
    "safety_level": "safe",
    "support_level": "fully_supportive",
    "support_note": "",
    "contact_frequency": "daily",
    "items_they_need_to_update": ["emergency-contact", "will-beneficiary", "joi
    "user_notes": "She came up with the 'things others need to update' section
  }
}
}

```

Safety levels: safe | probably_safe | unsure | probably_unsafe | unsafe | unknown

Support levels: fully_supportive | supportive_with_effort | words_not_actions |
neutral | resistant | actively_hostile | unknown

The distinction between safety and support matters. Someone can be safe (will not out you, will not harm you) but not supportive (does not use your name, does not understand).

Someone can claim to be supportive but be unsafe in practice. The app tracks these separately.

The people map is used to:

- Populate relationship blocker options when adding a blocker to an item
- Surface relevant coming out items in the social track
- Drive the “Things Others Need to Update” section
- Inform the safety filter on what is currently available

The people map is never used to judge whether the user should or should not come out to anyone. It is a tool for tracking reality, not prescribing action.

Application Screens and User Flow

1. Landing

- Brief explanation of what the app is
- “Start your checklist” — begins onboarding
- “I already have a checklist” — import JSON flow

- Link to GitHub repository

2. Onboarding Wizard

Step-by-step. No question is required. Every screen has a visible “Skip for now” option. The wizard can be re-entered and updated from settings at any time. Progress is saved as the user goes — closing the browser mid-onboarding does not lose their work.

Tone: warm, unhurried. Never clinical. Never assumes.

Step 1: Welcome

Key message: *“This is your tool. You decide what goes in it, what you share, and what you do with it. Nothing leaves your device.”*

Step 2: A little about you (all optional)

- What would you like to be called in this app? (free text, skippable)
 - Pronouns? (options: she/her, he/him, they/them, she/they, he/they, custom free text, prefer not to say, not sure yet)
 - What are you here for? (checkboxes — select any, all, or none)
 - Changing my legal name
 - Changing my gender marker
 - Navigating medical transition
 - Navigating social transition / coming out
 - Supporting someone else
 - Just exploring
 - If changing gender marker, what marker are you updating to? (free text, fully skippable)
-

Step 3: Where are you?

- Country (dropdown with search)
- Region / state (populates from country)

If no jurisdiction data exists in the KB: *"We do not have specific information for your area yet. We will still help you find the right direction for each item, and you can add what you discover."*

Step 4: What documents do you have?

"These help us figure out what steps are available to you right now."

- Court order / legal name change decree
- Updated birth certificate
- Updated Social Security card
- Updated government photo ID (driver's license, state ID, or passport)
- None of these yet
- Not sure

If none or not sure: *"That is completely fine. You can still build your list and see the full path ahead. We will highlight what is available to you now and what opens up as documents arrive."*

Step 5: Safety and access

"This helps us understand what is actually available to you right now. It also helps us flag things that might need more care in your situation. Everything here stays on your device."

Housing situation:

- Independent (alone or with a supportive household)
- Living with family or others who may not be supportive
- In transitional or unstable housing
- Prefer not to say

Account and device privacy:

- Private accounts and devices that only I access
- Some shared accounts or devices
- Mostly shared

- Complicated / prefer not to say

Workplace:

- Out at work and supported
- Out at work but complicated
- Not out at work
- Not currently employed
- Prefer not to say

Overall flexibility right now:

- A lot — I can move freely on most of this
- Some — there are areas where I need to be careful
- Not much — I need to be thoughtful about nearly everything
- It varies a lot by area

Getting places:

- Car
- Public transit
- Ride share / depends on someone else
- Limited mobility or transportation
- Prefer not to say

Access to equipment:

- Home printer/copier
- Printer/copier nearby (library, office store, etc.)
- Difficult to access
- Reliable phone
- Video call capable

"You can update any of this anytime. The app will never hide items from you based on your answers here — it will flag what needs extra care."

Step 6: How do you want this app to show up for you?

"Different people need different things from a tool like this. There is no right answer."

This sets the **presence level** — how actively the app participates. It can be changed at any time, and set differently for each track.

What would be most helpful overall?

- **Just the path** — Show me the checklist and stay out of the way. I will ask if I need more.
- **Some guidance** — I would appreciate context and occasional suggestions along the way.
- **Walk with me** — I am still working things out. I would welcome more support and gentle prompts toward things I might not think to look for.

None of these is more advanced or more valid than the others.

Would you like the app to occasionally surface things you might not know to look for — community groups, resources others have found helpful, ways to explore before making anything official?

- Yes
- No

You can set this differently for each track. For now your overall setting applies everywhere, and you can adjust per-track from the dashboard at any time.

Step 7: Walk through categories

For each track and category, show suggested items with checkboxes. User can:

- Check items that apply to them
- Add custom items within a category
- Mark items as not applicable
- Skip the whole category

No item is pre-checked. No pressure. Categories covering relationships, coming out, and personal exploration should note explicitly that timing and whether to do any of this at all is entirely the user's choice.

Step 8: Contributor preferences (final onboarding step, fully skippable)

“One more thing. This app gets better as more people use it and share what they learn. You decide how much you want to be part of that.”

See the Contributor Settings System section for full detail. This step surfaces the three dials (privacy, prompting, involvement) in plain language. It is the last step before the dashboard and can be skipped entirely.

Step 9: Summary and start

- Show what they have added
 - Show their starting queue: items currently available based on documents and safety profile
 - Surface any relevant danger flags given their profile (e.g., gender marker change in a restricted jurisdiction)
 - “Let’s go”
-

3. Dashboard

- Progress shown as items complete out of total, with a warm label — not a percentage, not a “you have X remaining” framing
- **Available now** — items currently unlocked based on documents, filtered by safety and access profile. This replaces the “easy wins” framing from earlier planning notes; that phrase must not appear in the app.
- **Start here** — the dependency-ordered recommended next step (one or two items, not a long list)
- **Danger flags banner** if the user’s profile intersects with any currently flagged items — links to a details page, not inline
- Category sections with status indicators
- **Blocked items** visible with “waiting on [X]” label — present but clearly not yet actionable
- Quick-add custom item
- Access filter toggle — “Show only what I can do with my current access”

- Track switcher (legal / medical / social / personal / supporter)
- Settings access always one tap away

4. Item Detail View

- Item name and description
- Process steps with mode labels (Online, By mail, By phone, By video call, In person — or combinations)
- Access requirements: what documents are needed, whether copies are required, whether travel is needed
- Estimated time and cost
- Official links
- Danger or caution banner if status is not `current` — see Danger Flags section
- Immutable notice if applicable — compassionate explanation and workarounds
- Discrimination note if applicable — empowering, not alarming (“Some people have needed to insist on this policy. Here is the official language. You have the right to ask for a manager.”)
- Presence-level content rendered based on user’s track setting
- User’s personal notes field (never shared without explicit action)
- Status selector with all six status options
- “Something’s wrong with this information” — opens contribution flow

4a. Danger Flags and Status Warnings

Items carry a `status` field on their process or gender marker data:

- `current` — verified and up to date
- `caution` — may be outdated; verify before proceeding
- `danger` — currently blocked, legally risky, or subject to active litigation or executive action
- `varies` — depends heavily on local jurisdiction or individual circumstances
- `unknown` — no verified information available for this jurisdiction

When `status` is `danger` : show a clearly visible warning block (not an icon alone) with plain-language explanation, date last verified, links to current legal resources, and a single matter-of-fact note that this is not legal advice. Do not repeat the legal advice disclaimer on every page — once per session is sufficient.

When `status` is `caution` or `unknown` : show a lower-intensity notice prompting the user to verify before acting.

The KB's `status_date` field is surfaced to the user so they can judge recency themselves.

5. Contribution Flow

When a user submits knowledge:

- Form pre-populated with current KB data for that item (if any)
- User fills in what they know: process steps, links, date verified, source
- On submit: app generates a pre-filled GitHub issue template (no account required) or a JSON file for a PR (account required)
- Personal notes are never included — only process knowledge

6. Settings

All onboarding answers are editable here at any time:

- Identity and name preferences
- Jurisdiction
- Documents obtained
- Safety and access profile
- Presence level (overall and per-track)
- Contributor settings
- Export / Import / Clear data

7. Export / Import / Clear

- Export: downloads `transition-companion-[date].json`
 - Import: upload a previously exported file; confirm before overwriting
 - Clear: wipe all local data; always prompt to export first
-

Transition Tracks

The app is organized around tracks — parallel journeys that happen simultaneously, at the user's own pace and in their own order. No track is a prerequisite for another. No track is required.

Track: Legal

Updating name and gender marker with government agencies, financial institutions, employers, and other legal entities. Has the most complex dependency ordering. Most affected by jurisdiction and current political climate. Danger flags are most relevant here.

Track: Medical

Accessing gender-affirming healthcare, navigating insurance, finding affirming providers. Includes finding informed consent clinics, understanding what documentation providers can and cannot require, managing records, and navigating insurance coverage and appeals.

Track: Social

Coming out — to yourself, to others, in various contexts. Building community. Navigating relationships. Each coming out is its own item on its own timeline. None is required.

Track: Personal / Identity

The internal, exploratory, self-defining work. Exploring name and pronoun options. Exploring gender expression. Connecting with others. Resources and community voices. Surfaced primarily at `walk_with_me` and `open_doors` levels.

Track: Supporter / Ally

For partners, family, friends, and others who love someone who is transitioning. Covers what they may need to update on their end (wills, emergency contacts, beneficiaries), how to support their person, and resources for their own wellbeing. Credit for this track concept goes to a partner of someone going through this process.

Each track:

- Has its own categories and items in the KB
- Can be added or removed from the user's active view at any time
- Contributes items to the shared checklist
- Has its own presence level setting

Categories and Suggested Items

Track: Legal

No Documents Required

Items that typically require no paperwork. Availability depends on the user's safety situation — the app will flag which of these are available given the user's profile. Someone sharing accounts with an unsupportive household member may not be able to update a streaming service without raising questions. The app does not pretend otherwise.

Items typically in this category:

- Streaming service display names (Netflix, Hulu, Disney+, Spotify, etc.)
- Social media display names
- Email display names (the display name, not the address itself)
- Gaming account display names
- Discord, Reddit, and most forum display names
- Password manager entries

Completing any of these is a real step forward. It counts.

Foundation / Legal Documents

These unlock most other legal items

- Court Order / Name Change Decree (starting point — cannot be skipped)
- Birth Certificate (vital records office — jurisdiction-specific)
- Social Security Administration
- Naturalization Certificate (if applicable)

Government ID

- Driver's License / State ID
- Passport
- Passport Card

- Global Entry / TSA PreCheck / Known Traveler Number
- Voter Registration
- Selective Service (if applicable)
- Tribal ID (if applicable)
- Military ID (if applicable)
- Professional Licenses (real estate, nursing, law, teaching, etc.)

Financial

Banking (user prompted to list each account separately):

- Checking accounts
- Savings accounts
- Joint accounts

Credit Cards (each listed separately)

Loans and Debt:

- Mortgage
- Auto loan
- Federal student loans (FSA ID / studentaid.gov)
- Private student loans
- Personal loans

Investment and Retirement:

- 401(k) / 403(b) through employer
- IRA
- Brokerage accounts
- Stock or equity grants
- Pension

Other Financial:

- PayPal

- Venmo
- Cash App
- Zelle (tied to bank — may update automatically)
- Cryptocurrency exchanges

Employment and Benefits

- HR / Payroll (legal name for W-2)
- Work email and directory listing
- Employee badge and building access
- Benefits portal
- HSA / FSA accounts
- Employer-provided life insurance
- Workers compensation records
- Professional email signatures

Healthcare (Legal Track)

- Health insurance card and records
- Primary care physician records
- All specialist records (listed separately)
- Dentist records
- Eye doctor records
- Mental health provider records
- Pharmacy records
- Hospital records (each hospital separately)
- Patient portal accounts (MyChart, etc.)
- Medicare / Medicaid (if applicable)
- Veterans Affairs (if applicable)

Housing

Renting:

- Landlord or property management
- Lease agreement

Owning:

- Mortgage servicer
- County assessor / property tax records
- HOA

Utilities:

- Electric
- Gas
- Water
- Internet / cable
- Mobile phone carrier

Education and Professional

- High school records and diploma
- College and university records (each institution separately)
- Professional degrees and certifications
- Bar membership (if applicable)
- Medical board licensure (if applicable)
- Alumni associations

Subscriptions and Online Accounts

Streaming: Netflix, Hulu, Disney+, Max, Apple TV+, Spotify, Apple Music, YouTube Premium

Shopping: Amazon, eBay, Etsy, Instacart, DoorDash, Grubhub

Social and Communications:

- Email addresses (Gmail, Outlook, etc.)
- Google account (drives many other services)
- Apple ID (drives many other services)
- Facebook / Meta
- Instagram
- Twitter / X
- TikTok
- Snapchat
- LinkedIn (also Employment)
- Reddit
- Discord
- Signal and WhatsApp

Productivity and Cloud:

- iCloud
- Google Drive / Workspace
- Dropbox
- Microsoft account
- Password manager
- Domain names and website registrations

Other:

- Gaming accounts (Steam, PlayStation, Xbox, Nintendo)
- Dating apps
- Airline frequent flyer programs
- Hotel loyalty programs
- Grocery store loyalty cards
- Gym and fitness memberships

Relationships and Legal Docs

Whether, when, and how to update these is entirely the user's choice. There is no "should" here.

- Emergency contact information on file with others
- Medical power of attorney
- Financial power of attorney
- Living will / advance directive
- Will and estate documents

Things Others Need to Update (For You)

For partners, family members, and allies. These are records someone else holds with your old name.

Credit for this section concept goes to a partner of someone going through this process, because the people who love you are part of this too.

- Wills where you are a beneficiary
- Life insurance policies where you are a beneficiary
- Joint financial accounts (co-owner's records)
- Emergency contacts others have on file for you
- Godparent or guardianship documents
- Trust documents where you are named
- School emergency contact records for your children
- Medical records where you are listed as next of kin

Things That Cannot Be Changed

Some records are historical documents. They record an event as it happened and cannot be amended. This is not a policy failure.

- Marriage certificate — records the event; cannot be amended in most US jurisdictions. Your court order is what matters legally. Bring both documents when proof of marriage is requested.

- Divorce decree — historical record
- Some older academic records depending on institution and year
- Original adoption records in some jurisdictions

Each item in this category is shown with a clear compassionate explanation and any applicable workarounds. The tone is: this is frustrating to discover, it does not affect your legal standing, and here is what actually works.

Track: Medical

Finding Affirming Care

- Finding a primary care physician who is knowledgeable and affirming
- Finding a gender-affirming therapist or counselor
- LGBTQ+ health centers by location (community-maintained KB)
- Planned Parenthood locations offering gender-affirming care
- Online and telehealth providers for HRT (where available and appropriate)

KB note: items in this category should include specific clinic networks, telehealth services, and directories where community-verified. This is where lived experience in the KB is most valuable.

Hormone Therapy (HRT)

Surfaced only for users who indicate interest. Never assumed or pre-checked.

- Understanding informed consent — what it is and that you can insist on it
 - “You do not need a therapist’s letter to get HRT from an informed consent provider. If a provider says otherwise, that is their clinic’s policy, not the law. You can seek care elsewhere or ask to speak to someone else.”
- Finding an informed consent provider
- What to expect at a first HRT appointment
- Understanding the bloodwork and monitoring schedule
- Insurance coverage for HRT — how to find out, how to appeal denials

- Managing HRT while traveling or in hostile jurisdictions
- What to do if your provider becomes unavailable

Medical Records and Insurance

- Updating name on insurance card and with insurer
 - Updating name in medical records at each provider
 - Understanding what gender marker on insurance means for coverage
 - Navigating prior authorizations for gender-affirming care
 - Appealing insurance denials (template letters — community resource)
-

Track: Social

Coming Out

Each of these is its own item. Each is on its own timeline. None is required.

- Coming out to yourself
 - This is a real step. Many people spend time here. It belongs on the list.
- Coming out to a partner or spouse
- Coming out to close friends
- Coming out to a parent (each parent separately)
- Coming out to siblings
- Coming out to extended family
- Coming out at work (manager, colleagues, HR — each can be separate)
- Coming out to a landlord or housing provider
- Coming out in a faith community
- Coming out publicly or on social media

KB note: items in this category include community-written guides, suggested approaches, what to do if it goes badly, and support resources. These are not checklists — they are conversations. The KB should treat them that way.

Community and Support

- Finding local LGBTQ+ community groups
- Finding online communities
- Trans-specific peer support groups
- Resources for partners and family (to share with them)
- Chosen family

Resources and Learning

- Books, memoirs, and community voices (curated, community-maintained)
 - Organizations: ACLU, Lambda Legal, NCTE, Trevor Project, PFLAG, and others
-

Blocker System

Every item can have zero or more blockers. A blocker is any reason — bureaucratic, legal, financial, personal, relational, or circumstantial — why an item cannot be acted on right now. The app does not rank blockers by legitimacy or severity. The user defines what is blocking them. Waiting for a law to change and waiting for grandma to die are both valid blockers that deserve equal respect in the data model and in the UI.

The origin of this project as a legal process tracker created an incorrect implicit assumption: that the only blockers are bureaucratic ones (missing documents, wrong order). That assumption is removed. Every item is aware of every possible way it could be blocked, and every blocker is treated as exactly as significant as the user says it is.

Blocker Types

document — a required document is not yet obtained

- Example: "Need updated driver's license before the bank will process this"
- Often has a clear resolution path; the dependency graph handles these automatically
- May have workarounds (some institutions accept a court order alone)

legal — a law, policy, or active legal situation is blocking this

- Example: "Gender marker X is not currently available in this state"
- Example: "Federal passport policy is under active litigation"

- May be temporary; the app resurfaces when jurisdiction status changes
- Workarounds may exist (a different jurisdiction, a different document)

access — a practical access barrier

- Example: "No reliable internet for the online form"
- Example: "Cannot get to this office without a car"
- Example: "Cannot afford the fee right now"
- Often resolvable; workarounds commonly exist (library, telehealth, fee waiver programs)

safety — proceeding would create a risk to the user's safety or stability

- Example: "My landlord would find out and I am not sure that is safe"
- Example: "I am financially dependent on someone who is not supportive"
- The app does not question or minimize these. Safety blockers are treated with maximum respect.
- Workarounds may exist; the app surfaces them only if the user asks

relationship — a specific person or relationship is a factor

- Example: "Not sure my aunt is safe to tell"
- Example: "My dad says he supports me but I am not ready to test it"
- Links to the people map (see People Map section below)
- Workarounds may exist and are surfaced gently: some things a given person will never need to know about

readiness — the user is not ready yet, for any reason

- Example: "I am not sure about my name yet"
- Example: "I need more time before I come out at work"
- Never questioned, never pushed. Readiness is entirely self-defined.
- No workaround is appropriate for a readiness blocker

waiting — blocked on an external timeline with no clear action available

- Example: "Waiting for the law to change"
- Example: "Waiting until I turn 18"

- Example: “Waiting for a family situation to resolve”
- Some waiting blockers have a known resolution date; some do not and may never

custom — anything that does not fit the above

- Free text, user-defined
- Treated with the same respect as any other blocker type

Blocker Data Model

```
{
  "id": "blocker-003",
  "type": "relationship",
  "label": "Not sure grandma would understand",
  "person_ref": "person-grandma",
  "user_defined": true,
  "severity": "significant",
  "resolvable": "eventually",
  "resolvable_note": "This may not resolve in her lifetime. That is okay.",
  "workaround_available": true,
  "workaround_note": "She will never need to see your passport or most legal docu",
  "suppress_workaround": false
}
```

severity is user-defined: minor | moderate | significant | absolute

resolvable: yes | no | maybe | eventually | unknown

suppress_workaround: if `true`, the app will not offer the workaround for this blocker. Some users do not want workaround suggestions for certain blockers — particularly safety and readiness blockers. This is a per-blocker user preference.

How the Dashboard Uses Blockers

The “available now” section shows items with no active blockers. Blocked items are shown separately with their blocker label visible — the user can always see everything, but the interface makes clear what is and is not currently actionable.

When a blocker has a known resolution path, the app can show: “This becomes available when [X] is complete.”

When a blocker has a workaround, the app surfaces it at `some_guidance` and `walk_with_me` presence levels. At `just_the_path`, workarounds are available on the item detail page but not proactively surfaced.

The app never tells a user their blocker is not real, not serious, or should be reconsidered.

Order of Operations Logic

The app tracks a directed dependency graph for document-type blockers. Each KB item declares:

- `requires` — items whose completion removes a document blocker on this item
- `required_by` — items this one's completion will unblock

The dashboard uses this graph to:

1. Show which items have no active blockers (available now)
2. Show which items are blocked and surface the primary blocker
3. Surface the recommended next step toward the user's goals

User-defined blockers (relationship, safety, readiness, waiting, custom) are not part of the dependency graph. They are managed separately and never automatically resolved by the app. Only the user can mark a user-defined blocker as resolved.

Default US document dependency chain:

```
Court Order
  +-- Social Security
    +-- Driver's License / State ID
      +-- Passport
      +-- Banks and Financial Institutions
        +-- Employer HR
        +-- Healthcare legal name update
    +-- Birth Certificate (state vital records, parallel path)
```

The dependency graph applies to document-type blockers in the legal track. Medical and social tracks do not have hard document dependencies — items in those tracks may have other blocker types but are not gated by legal documents.

Progress Revocation and Status Threats

This is the most sensitive area of the app. People will encounter `at_risk` and `revoked` states after receiving hostile official correspondence, after losing insurance coverage, after

being deliberately misgendered by an institution that previously recognized them, after a law changed that they did not vote for and cannot control. The messaging here requires more care than anywhere else in the application.

The Core Principle

The user did the work. The status change is not their failure. Something was done to them by forces outside their control. The app must communicate this implicitly through every word it chooses — through restraint, through steadiness, through not using bureaucratic neutral language that erases the agent of harm.

Item Statuses: Complete Is Not Terminal

`complete` is not a permanent terminal state. External events — policy changes, executive actions, hostile institutions — can move items to `at_risk` or `revoked`. The user's history of completing the item is always preserved. The app never implies the user did anything wrong.

`at_risk` — was complete; now under threat due to legal or policy changes outside the user's control. The user's status has not necessarily changed yet — they should be aware and may want to take action.

`revoked` — was complete; has been actively reversed by an external party. The user has reported this directly.

These two statuses are distinct. `at_risk` is a warning. `revoked` is a recorded fact the user has reported. The app never assumes a revocation has occurred — it only surfaces alerts. The user is always the source of truth.

If a status is later restored — through a court ruling, a policy reversal, or the user successfully challenging a decision — they can mark it complete again. All history is preserved.

Status Change Log

Every item maintains a full log of status changes. Nothing is overwritten.

```
{
  "us-drivers-license-il": {
    "status": "revoked",
    "status_log": [
      {
        "status": "complete",
        "at": "2024-12-01",
        "note": "Got the X marker with no issues. Staff were great."
      }
    ]
  }
}
```

```

    },
    {
      "status": "at_risk",
      "at": "2025-03-15",
      "reason": "jurisdiction_policy_change",
      "triggered_by": "kb_update",
      "kb_ref": "us-il-gender-marker-2025"
    },
    {
      "status": "revoked",
      "at": "2025-04-02",
      "reason": "user_reported",
      "note": "Got a letter. They reverted my marker to M without my consent."
    }
  ]
}
}

```

The log belongs to the user. It is exported with their data. It is never deleted by the app.

Alert Messaging Guidelines

When the app surfaces an `at_risk` alert, the message must:

- Acknowledge what the user accomplished — the work they did was real and valid
- Name what has changed in plain language, without bureaucratic neutrality
- Be specific about what is actually at risk and what is not — not everything changes at once
- Not catastrophize — the user may be less affected than a general alert implies
- Offer next steps if they exist, without pressure
- Link to current legal resources
- State once, clearly, that this is not legal advice and that a legal organization can help
- Not repeat as a notification on every subsequent visit after the user has acknowledged it

The alert is not a modal. It is not a banner the user must dismiss to use the app. It is a clearly marked section on the item detail page, and a summary notice on the dashboard that the user can expand or collapse. Once acknowledged, it becomes a quieter indicator unless the status changes again.

Example alert copy (`at_risk`, gender marker):

Your Illinois gender marker was updated in December 2024. A policy change in March 2025 has put gender marker X designations in this state under threat. Your license remains valid as of the date this information was last verified — but this is a situation worth monitoring.

If you receive any correspondence about your license or identity documents, a trans legal organization can help you understand your options. This is not legal advice.

[Lambda Legal] [ACLU Trans Rights] [NCTE] [Last verified: 2025-03-20]

Example alert copy (revoked, user-reported):

This copy should be minimal. The revocation detail view has room for the user's own notes. The app's framing is present, factual, and steady.

You recorded that this was reverted on [date]. Your record of completing this in [month] is preserved.

If you want to understand your options or challenge this, a trans legal organization may be able to help.

[Lambda Legal] [ACLU Trans Rights] [NCTE]

No "we're sorry this happened." No "unfortunately." Sympathy is expressed through restraint, not through words that center the app's reaction. The user does not need the app to perform grief. They need it to be steady.

Dashboard Treatment of At-Risk and Revoked Items

`at_risk` items: shown with a clear but calm indicator. Grouped in a "Needs attention" section if the user has any. Not intermixed with completed items without differentiation.

`revoked` items: shown separately from both complete and at-risk items. History is visible. A path forward — redo, workaround, legal resource — is surfaced if one exists.

The progress count does not subtract revoked or at-risk items from the user's completed total. A revocation does not erase what the user did. The count might read "47 completed, 2 need attention" rather than "45 completed."

KB-Triggered Alerts

When a KB update changes an item's status to `danger` or `varies`, the app checks whether the user has that item marked `complete`. If so, it queues an `at_risk` notice for that item on next load.

The notice is surfaced once, clearly, and then persists as a quieter indicator. It does not

repeat on every visit. The app never changes the user's item status automatically — it only surfaces the alert and lets the user decide what it means for their situation.

People Map

The people map is an optional private record of the people in the user's life and their relationship to the user's transition. Nothing about it is required. It exists to be useful when the user needs it, not as a task to complete.

It serves three purposes:

1. Populates relationship blocker options when adding a blocker to an item
2. Feeds the "Things Others Need to Update" section of the legal track
3. Informs social track items — coming out steps can reference specific people from the map

It does not tell the user what to do about any person.

Person Record

```
{
  "id": "person-aunt-margaret",
  "label": "Aunt Margaret",
  "relationship": "extended_family",
  "out_to": false,
  "out_status": "not_out",
  "safety_level": "unsure",
  "safety_note": "Never talks politics. Hard to read. Gave me a gender-affirming",
  "support_level": null,
  "support_note": null,
  "contact_frequency": "holidays_only",
  "items_they_need_to_update": [],
  "user_notes": ""
}
```

Relationship types (suggested; user can add custom): partner | spouse | parent | sibling | child | close_friend | colleague | manager | extended_family | neighbor | religious_community | other

Out status: not_out | out | partially_out | they_figured_it_out | unknown

Safety levels: safe | probably_safe | unsure | probably_unsafe | unsafe | unknown

Support levels: `fully_supportive` | `supportive_with_effort` | `words_not_actions` | `neutral` | `resistant` | `actively_hostile` | `unknown`

Safety and support are separate fields because they describe different things:

- Someone can be safe (will not out you, will not harm you) but not supportive (does not use your name, still slips)
- Someone can claim to be supportive but be unsafe in practice (tells others without asking)
- "Words not actions" is its own real category that many people will recognize immediately
- Safety is about risk to the user. Support is about the quality of the relationship.

Neither field is required. A person can be added with nothing but a label. The user fills in what they know, when they know it.

People Map in the UI

The people map lives in the social track and in the profile/settings area. It is not a prominent feature of the legal track dashboard. It surfaces when relevant — when adding a relationship blocker to an item, when viewing social track coming out items, when reviewing "Things Others Need to Update."

The app never presents the people map as something to fill out or complete.

Presence Level System

The app has three presence levels, settable overall and per-track. These control how actively the app participates — not what data is available, but how much context, guidance, and prompting the app offers.

`just_the_path`

- Checklist, status, notes, process steps, and links
- No extra prompts, no suggestions, no reflective nudges
- Danger flags and safety warnings always appear regardless of level — those are safety information, not guidance
- The app is a tool. It stays out of the way.

`some_guidance`

- Everything in `just_the_path`
- Context and explanation surfaced inline where it might help
- Occasional prompts when completing an item unlocks something new
- KB resources linked where relevant
- Suggested next steps offered, not pushed

walk_with_me

- Everything in `some_guidance`
- Reflective nudges for items where emotional weight is common
- Proactive surfacing of resources, community, and exploration prompts (if `open_doors` is enabled)
- Coming out items, identity exploration, and community resources are surfaced naturally
- The app notices where someone might be and gently offers what others have found useful

The `open_doors` setting is independent of presence level. It controls whether the app surfaces things the user might not have thought to look for — a community group, a way to try out a name before making it official, a resource someone found helpful. A

`just_the_path` user can enable `open_doors` if they want occasional discovery prompts without active guidance.

What presence level is not:

- Not a measure of certainty or readiness
- Not a hierarchy — `just_the_path` is not more advanced
- Not permanent — changes take effect immediately
- Not global when per-track overrides are set

Implementation guidance:

- Presence level affects component rendering, not data — all items exist and are accessible at every level
- `presence_level_content` in KB items is tagged by level; content only renders at that level or above
- Per-track settings override the global setting for that track only

- Settings UI is always reachable in one tap from the dashboard
-

Contributor Settings System

Contributing back to the project is opt-in at every level. The settings are three independent dials, not a single slider, because the combinations are genuinely different experiences.

Dial 1: Privacy (what leaves your device)

- `private` — Nothing ever leaves your device. No prompts, no sharing, no submissions.
- `manual` — You can share things, but only when you explicitly choose to. Never automatic.
- `auto` — You have opted in to automatic quiet contributions (e.g., stamping a verification date when you complete an item with a stale `last_verified`).

Dial 2: Prompting (when the app mentions contributing)

- `never` — Never prompt me. I know where to find it if I want it.
- `contextual` — Prompt me when I do something that would obviously help others.
- `proactive` — Surface contribution opportunities actively. I want to help.

Dial 3: Involvement (how deep into the project)

- `user` — Contribution is a bonus, not a goal.
- `contributor` — I want to submit things I find. Keep it simple — issues and forms, not Git.
- `maintainer_in_training` — Walk me through PRs, reviews, and repo management as I go.

Contributor Onboarding (final onboarding step)

“One more thing. This app gets better as more people use it and share what they learn. You decide how much you want to be part of that.”

Privacy:

- **Keep everything private** — I am just here for me. Nothing leaves this device.
- **I will share when I choose** — I might contribute sometimes, but only when I decide to.

- **Auto-share verifications** — When I complete something, quietly note that the information was current as of today.

Prompting (shown only if privacy is not `private`):

- **Never ask** — I know where to find it if I want it.
- **Ask when it makes sense** — If I do something that would obviously help others, mention it once.
- **Help me help people** — Surface contribution opportunities actively. I want to be useful.

Involvement (shown only if privacy is not `private`):

- **Just a user** — Contributing is a bonus, not a goal.
- **Occasional contributor** — I will submit things I find. Keep it simple.
- **Teach me to help run this** — I want to learn GitHub and help maintain this project.

Contextual Prompts

When prompting is `contextual` or `proactive`, the app watches for natural contribution moments:

- Completing an item with process notes → "Your notes about [institution] might help others. Want to share just the process information, not your personal notes?"
- Completing a KB item with a stale `last_verified` date → "You just did this. Want to mark the information as verified as of today? That helps everyone know it is current."
- Adding a custom item not in the KB → "[Item] is not in the knowledge base yet. Want to add it so others can find it?"
- Hitting a danger-flagged item → "If you have current information about this, the community needs it. Verified, dated policy information is especially valuable right now."

Maintainer-in-Training Path

A progressive journey into GitHub project management, surfaced as optional steps inside the app:

1. Create a GitHub account (guided, with links)
2. Submit a pre-filled issue via the app's contribution form
3. Fork the repo and submit a PR using an app-generated template
4. Review open issues and learn to validate JSON schema

5. Added as a collaborator by the project owner

Each step is optional and acknowledged when completed.

Contribution Templates

New Item:

New Item Submission

Institution / step / resource name:

Category:

Track:

Country / Region:

Process summary:

Steps:

1.

Documents required:

Can this be done online: Yes / No

Official URL:

I verified this on: [date]

Source:

Correction or Update:

Process Update

Item:

What is wrong or outdated:

What it should say:

Source:

Verified on:

Maintainer PR Review Checklist

- Schema validates against item.schema.json
- Official source linked
- Date verified is recent
- No personal information in submission
- Jurisdiction tagged correctly
- Status field is accurate and dated

Design Principles

Philosophy: The Crystal Goblet

Beatrice Warde's crystal goblet principle applies here: the interface should be invisible. The user's process, their emotional state, their checklist — that is the content. The UI is the vessel. Any design element that draws attention to itself rather than to the content is a failure.

This means:

- No emoji in UI, labels, copy, or the knowledge base — anywhere
- No decorative flourishes
- No motivational micro-copy that feels performative
- Restraint in color, weight, and animation
- If a design element is not doing functional work, remove it

Icons

- No emoji as icons under any circumstances
- Source from a single consistent royalty-free vector set — Lucide or Phosphor; Claude Code should pick one at project start and use it exclusively throughout the app
- Specific one-off icons may come from the Noun Project (CC license; cite the contributor in project credits)
- Icons clarify; they do not decorate
- Every icon must have a visible text label — no icon-only controls ever
- When in doubt, use text instead of an icon

Typography and Layout

- Clean, readable type with sufficient size, generous line height, and real contrast
- Hierarchy through scale and weight, not color alone
- Adequate whitespace — this is not a dashboard trying to show everything at once
- Mobile-first; single column where possible

Color

- Minimal palette — neutral base, one accent color maximum
- Never use color as the only means of conveying information
- WCAG AA contrast minimum throughout; AAA where feasible

Accessibility (non-negotiable)

- WCAG AA minimum; AAA where feasible
- Full keyboard navigation
- Semantic HTML with proper ARIA labels and logical heading structure
- No time-sensitive interactions
- Respect `prefers-reduced-motion` — no motion that cannot be disabled
- Touch targets minimum 44x44px on mobile

Internationalization and Localization

- All UI strings externalized via `react-i18next` from day one — no hardcoded copy in components
- Design layouts that accommodate text expansion (some languages run 30-40% longer than English)
- Avoid idioms and culturally specific metaphors in UI copy
- Date, number, and currency formatting through locale-aware APIs from the start
- The KB is already structured by jurisdiction — the UI treats locale as a first-class concern, not a retrofit
- Right-to-left layout support is out of scope for v1 but the architecture must not preclude it

Tone in Copy

- Warm, direct, unhurried
- Plain language — no jargon, no legalese, no bureaucratic hedging
- Never condescending; never performatively cheerful
- Acknowledges difficulty without dwelling on it

- Trusts the user completely — does not over-explain things they already know
- Does not add disclaimers to things that do not need them

Error Handling

The app is used on library computers, shared devices, slow mobile connections, and in stressful circumstances. Errors must be handled gracefully, explained in plain language, and never presented as technical messages.

Knowledge Base Unavailable

If the app cannot reach GitHub and has no cached KB:

- Load the bundled KB snapshot silently (this is the normal offline path)
- Show a small, unobtrusive notice: "You are using an offline version of the knowledge base. Some information may not be current."
- Do not block the user or show an error state — the bundled snapshot is sufficient for full use

If the bundled snapshot fails to load (should not happen in normal operation):

- Show the checklist with the user's own items intact
- Show a notice: "We could not load the knowledge base right now. Your checklist is still here. Try refreshing when you have a connection."
- Never show a blank screen or a technical error

Import Errors

If a user uploads a JSON file that cannot be parsed:

- Do not silently discard or partially import
- Show: "We could not read that file. It may be corrupted or in the wrong format. Your current data has not been changed."
- Offer to try again or start fresh
- Never overwrite existing data on a failed import

If the file is valid JSON but from an incompatible version:

- Attempt to migrate known fields; ignore unknown ones

- Show: "This file is from an older version of Transition Companion. We imported what we could. Check your settings to make sure everything looks right."

localStorage Full

If localStorage is full (typically 5-10 MB limit):

- Catch the write error before it fails silently
- Show: "Your device's storage for this app is full. You may want to export your data and then clear it to free up space."
- Provide a direct path to Export from the error message
- Never silently drop data

GitHub Rate Limiting

The app fetches KB items from GitHub's raw content CDN, which has generous limits for unauthenticated requests. If rate limiting occurs:

- Fall back to the cached KB silently
- Do not surface rate limit errors to the user
- Log to console for debugging

Network Errors Mid-Session

If a network request fails during normal use:

- Use cached data and proceed
- Do not interrupt the user's flow
- Do not show spinner states that hang indefinitely — set a reasonable timeout (5 seconds) and fall back to cache

General Error Principle

No error message in the app should contain:

- HTTP status codes
- Stack traces
- Technical jargon
- Blame ("an unexpected error occurred")

Every error message should:

- Say what happened in plain language
 - Say whether the user's data is safe
 - Offer a clear next step
 - Be as brief as possible
-

Privacy and Safety

- **No analytics by default** — if analytics are added later, they must be opt-in
 - **No external calls except GitHub** — and only for KB data, never user data
 - **Chosen name vs. legal name** — the app displays the user's chosen name in the UI regardless of legal name change status. These are separate things.
 - **Not everyone is out everywhere** — onboarding and all UI copy make clear that partial use is completely valid. Someone might only ever update their streaming accounts. That is a legitimate and complete use of this tool.
 - **Data deletion** — one-tap wipe of all local data, always accessible from settings. Always prompt to export first.
 - **Shared and monitored devices** — a quick-exit button and privacy mode are out of scope for v1 but the architecture should not preclude them. Note for future implementation.
 - **KB political neutrality** — the KB presents factual status of laws and policies, including when they are hostile, without editorializing. It links to advocacy organizations for action rather than embedding advocacy in KB content.
 - **Status fields are dated** — every status field in the KB includes a `status_date` so users can judge recency. Outdated information without a date is more dangerous than a `caution` flag with one.
-

Technical Stack

Frontend

- **React with Vite** — SPA, static output, no server required

- **React Router** — client-side routing
- **Zustand** — lightweight state management
- **react-i18next** — internationalization; all UI strings externalized from day one
- **Tailwind CSS** — utility-first styling
- **One icon library** (Lucide or Phosphor — pick one at project start and use it exclusively)
- No backend, no database, no authentication

Knowledge Base

- **GitHub** — source of truth
- **GitHub raw content CDN** for fetching:
`https://raw.githubusercontent.com/[org]/transition-kb/main/items/[slug].json`
- KB data cached in `tc_kb_cache` `localStorage` key with 24-hour TTL
- App ships with a bundled KB snapshot (static import in `public/kb-snapshot/`) as offline fallback
- User data stored separately in `tc_user_data` `localStorage` key

Deployment

- `npm run build` produces static files in `dist/`
- Upload `dist/` to existing web host via FTP
- No server-side requirements
- Recommended subdirectory or subdomain: `yoursite.com/companion/` or `companion.yoursite.com`
- Optional: GitHub Actions to auto-deploy on push to `main`

Phased Implementation Plan

Phase 1 — Personal Use (Legal Track, US / Illinois)

Goal: Useful for the project creator, right now

- Onboarding wizard (all steps)

- Legal track: full category and item structure
- Checklist with all six status types
- Dependency graph and order-of-operations view
- “Available now” section on dashboard, filtered by safety profile
- Danger flag display on item detail
- Immutable item handling with compassionate copy
- Process steps with mode labels
- Access requirements per item
- Presence level system (rendering, not just data model)
- localStorage persistence with separate keys for user data and KB cache
- Export and import as `transition-companion-[date].json`
- Bundled KB snapshot for offline use
- Error handling for all documented scenarios
- US federal + Illinois KB seed (~25-30 items with accurate current data)
- i18n scaffolded from day one even if only English is populated

Phase 2 — Community Ready, Medical Track

Goal: Useful for others; contribution pipeline working; medical track functional

- Contributor settings system fully implemented
- Contribution UI (issue and PR generation)
- KB schema validation as GitHub Action on PR
- Medical track: finding affirming care, HRT informed consent, insurance navigation
- More legal items (~100+)
- Additional US states
- CONTRIBUTING.md, README, community documentation
- “Something’s wrong with this information” flag on every item
- Maintainer-in-training onboarding path

Phase 3 — Full Scope

Goal: All tracks, broad jurisdictions, full community tool

- Social track: coming out guides, community resources
 - Personal / Identity track
 - Supporter / Ally track
 - Non-US jurisdictions (UK, Canada, Australia as first additions)
 - Printable checklist export (PDF)
 - Shareable checklist link (state encoded in URL, no server needed)
 - Privacy mode / quick-exit for shared devices
-

Initial KB Seed (US / Illinois)

Build these first, in order, with complete and current data:

Legal Foundation:

1. Social Security Administration (name change only — gender marker flagged as danger)
2. Illinois Driver's License / State ID (includes gender marker X)
3. Illinois Vital Records (birth certificate)
4. US Passport
5. US Passport Card

Government and Civic: 6. Illinois Voter Registration 7. USPS Informed Delivery 8. Federal Student Aid / FSA ID 9. IRS (name auto-updates from SSA; note what does and does not need action)

Financial (generic templates): 10. Bank of America 11. Chase 12. Wells Fargo 13. Generic bank template (for user-added institutions)

Employment: 14. Generic employer HR template

Healthcare: 15. Generic health insurance template

Accounts (no documents required): 16. Google Account 17. Apple ID 18. Amazon 19. Netflix (display name) 20. Hulu (display name)

Immutable: 21. US Marriage Certificate

Medical Track: 22. Informed Consent — what it is and how to use it (resource item, not an institution) 23. LGBTQ+ health center directory (resource item, community-maintained links)

Handoff Notes for Claude Code

Starting prompt

“Build the Transition Companion app according to this design document. The app is a gender transition checklist manager and community knowledge base. Start with: (1) project scaffold with Vite + React + Zustand + react-i18next + Tailwind, (2) the localStorage data layer and KB fetching/caching utilities, (3) the onboarding wizard. The design document is the source of truth for all decisions.”

Suggested build sequence

Session 1 — Scaffold and data layer

- Vite + React + Zustand + react-i18next + Tailwind project setup
- localStorage utilities (`tc_user_data` and `tc_kb_cache` as separate keys)
- KB fetching, caching (24hr TTL), and bundled snapshot fallback
- Blocker data model and dependency graph logic (`ordering.js`)
- Status change log model (including `at_risk` and `revoked`)
- People map data model
- Export and import as `transition-companion-[date].json`

Session 2 — Onboarding wizard

- All 9 onboarding steps in sequence
- Presence level selection (overall + per-track)
- Safety and access inventory
- Contributor preferences
- Saves state progressively; resumable if closed mid-flow

Session 3 — Dashboard and checklist

- Track switcher (legal / medical / social / personal / supporter)
- "Available now" section filtered by blockers and safety profile
- "Needs attention" section for `at_risk` and `revoked` items
- Blocked items with primary blocker label
- Progress count that preserves completed total through revocations
- Quick-add custom item

Session 4 — Item detail and blocker UI

- Full item detail view with process steps and mode labels
- Blocker add/edit/resolve flow (all 8 blocker types)
- Workaround surfacing at appropriate presence levels
- Danger flag and status warning display
- Immutable item display with compassionate copy
- Discrimination notes display
- Status selector including `cant_right_now`, `at_risk`, `revoked`
- Status change log view

Session 5 — Revocation alerts and people map

- KB-triggered `at_risk` alert queue and display
- Alert messaging following the guidelines in the Progress Revocation section exactly
- People map UI (add, edit, view person records)
- People map integration with relationship blocker type
- "Things Others Need to Update" driven by people map

Session 6 — Contribution flow and settings

- Contribution form (new item and correction templates)
- GitHub issue and PR generation
- Maintainer-in-training path
- Full settings screen (all onboarding answers editable)

- Clear data flow with export prompt

Key constraints to enforce throughout

- No emoji anywhere in the UI, copy, components, or KB files — anywhere
- No hardcoded UI strings — all text goes through i18n from day one
- Presence level affects rendering, not data — all items are always accessible at every level
- User data (`tc_user_data`) and KB cache (`tc_kb_cache`) are separate `localStorage` keys
- Bundled KB snapshot is a static import in `public/kb-snapshot/` , not in `localStorage`
- The phrase “easy wins” must not appear anywhere in the app
- All error messages in plain language — no technical jargon, no HTTP status codes
- Every icon must have a visible text label — no icon-only controls ever
- Pick one icon library (Lucide or Phosphor) at project start and use it exclusively
- The app never changes a user’s item status automatically — only the user can do that
- The status change log is append-only — nothing is ever overwritten or deleted
- Revocation and at-risk alert copy must follow the messaging guidelines in this document exactly — do not improvise friendlier or more sympathetic language; restraint is the correct tone
- The people map is never presented as a task to complete or a form to fill out
- Safety blockers and readiness blockers never get unsolicited workaround suggestions

Files to provide alongside this document

1. This design document
2. `item.schema.json` — the KB item JSON schema (derived from the Institution schema in this doc)
3. Three example KB item files: `us-social-security.json` , `il-drivers-license.json` , `us-marriage-certificate.json`
4. One example immutable item: `us-marriage-certificate.json`
5. One example user data JSON (`sample-user-data.json`) including a person in the people map, a blocked item, and an at-risk item

6. One example jurisdiction override (`us-il.json`)